

HIPAA Compliance Alert: Protecting Patient Privacy in Our Practice (Updated for 2026)

This poster serves as a critical guide to our collective responsibility to uphold HIPAA standards, ensuring our practice remains defensible and patient data is secure.

Your Core Responsibilities: The Daily Do's & Don'ts

-  **Always Follow the "Minimum Necessary" Rule**
Only access, use, or disclose the absolute minimum amount of Protected Health Information (PHI) required to perform your job function.
-  **Lock Unattended Computers**
Lock when leaving. Auto-lock after 15 minutes.
-  **Secure Paper Records**
Keep PHI documents face down or stored in locked areas.
-  **Never Share Your Password**
Unique ID. No sharing. Change every 50 days.
-  **Safeguard Conversations**
Avoid overheard discussions. Verify caller identity before releasing PHI.



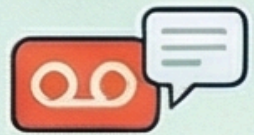
Patient Rights Our Practice Must Uphold

-  **Right to Access Records**
Provide copies within 30 days.
-  **Update Notice of Privacy Practices (NPP)**
Update by Feb 16, 2026, for new reproductive health info rules.
-  **Right to File Complaints**
Patients can complain to Privacy Officer or HHS. No retaliation.

CRITICAL UPDATE: Breach Reporting

-  **What is a Breach?**
Any unauthorized acquisition, access, use, or disclosure of PHI.
-  **Report Potential Breaches IMMEDIATELY**
Report to Privacy Officer immediately if a breach is suspected.
-  **New 15-Day Reporting Mandate**
Breaches must be reported within 16 days. Update internal policies.

Action Required: New 2026 Mandates

-  **Leave Vague Voicemails**
Limit messages to name, call-back request, and number. No clinical info.
-  **Encryption is Now Required**
Encrypt all PHI "at rest" and "in transit".
-  **Conduct a Security Risk Assessment**
Documented Security Risk Analysis required, failure can mean maximum fines.
-  **Update Business Associate Agreements (BAAs)**
Update all vendor contracts handling PHI with new language.
-  **Document All Staff Training**
Document all training sessions and periodic security reminders.